

Texas A&M - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | SEC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Top-10 contender quality with an established quarterback, excellent 2025 play-level efficiency and a deep skill/secondary core, but unusually concentrated replacement risk in both trenches.
Preseason consensus	AP No. 8 · SEC media 4th (5 first-place votes) · SP+ No. 9
Returning production	65% (No. 13) overall · Off. 67% (No. 19) · Def. 63% (No. 21)
Primer power rating	+21.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	8.5 wins · most likely 9-3
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ Similar contender tier, but less proven in the trenches after an 11-2 season with elite play-level efficiency.
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: QB Marcel Reed leads a flexible offense with WR Mario Craver, WR Terry Bussey, RB Rueben Owens II and WR Isaiah Horton. HC Mike Elko's defense retains veteran safeties but must rebuild the front.

Bottom line: Texas A&M has top-10 contender quality, but its playoff ceiling depends on replacing seven drafted linemen and additional front-seven losses without a major efficiency drop.

Beats expectations if: QB Marcel Reed stays efficient, the new OL settles around C Mark Nabou Jr., and DT DJ Hicks plus the imported front recreate enough disruption for S Marcus Ratcliffe and S Dalton Brooks.

Disappoints if: Four new OL jobs fail to stabilize, the rebuilt front loses 2025's havoc/success-rate strength, and open CB/LB roles are exposed during the brutal five-game finish.

Five things to remember

- 1 QB stability:** QB Marcel Reed is the established QB1; QB Brady Hart entered camp as the explicit QB2, so quarterback uncertainty is not the central preseason issue.
- 2 2025 baseline:** The 2025 efficiency profile was contender-level on both sides: offensive opponent-adjusted rating No.6/EPA No.10, defensive EPA allowed No.11/success rate allowed No.6, and both havoc measures ranked No.4.
- 3 Offensive line:** Four 2025 offensive linemen were drafted; C Mark Nabou Jr. is the established center and OL Tyree Adams, OL Coen Echols, OL Trovon Baugh and OL Wilkin Formby are among the transfer candidates for the other jobs.
- 4 NFL departures:** The defensive front also undergoes a major reset after DL/Edge Cashius Howell, DL/Edge Tyler Onyedim and DL/Edge Albert Regis were drafted and DE Dayon Hayes departed, with DT DJ Hicks anchoring a large transfer wave.
- 5 Schedule pressure:** The schedule is a top-15 SOS and closes with a five-game contender gauntlet: at Alabama, at South Carolina, Tennessee, at Oklahoma and Texas.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	11-2 (7-1 SEC)	● Excellent
Scoring	33.8 PPG	● Very good
Total offense	444.5 YPG	● Very good
Rush offense	184.7 YPG · 4.8 YPC	● Very good
Pass efficiency	8.28 YPA · 26 TD / 14 INT	● Good / above average
Third downs	41.3%	● Average / mixed
Scoring defense	21.0 PPG allowed	● Good / above average
Total defense	307.4 YPG allowed	● Very good
Rush defense	130.8 YPG · 4.2 YPC	● Good / above average
Pass defense	176.6 YPG · 6.03 YPA · 17 TD allowed	● Very good

Texas A&M's 11-2 record reflected balance rather than one dominant phase: the offense was very good across scoring, yardage and rushing, while the defense was especially strong at limiting total and passing yardage. Third-down offense was the closest thing to an ordinary result.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+10.83 · No. 6	● Elite
Off. EPA/play	+0.196 · No. 10	● Elite
Off. success rate	47.0% · No. 30	● Very good
Off. explosive-play rate	14.8% · No. 17	● Very good
Havoc allowed	10.4% · No. 4	● Elite
Opp.-adjusted defense	+5.94 · No. 22	● Very good
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.166 · No. 11	● Elite
Def. success rate allowed	33.4% · No. 6	● Elite
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	13.3% · No. 109	● Poor
Havoc created	21.2% · No. 4	● Elite

Advanced-stat read: Texas A&M paired a No. 6 opponent-adjusted offense with elite defensive EPA, success rate and havoc. The clear flaw was No. 109 explosive-play prevention; rebuilt OL/DL groups now must preserve the strong down-to-down profile.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Mike Elko - returning	● ↔ Program and defensive-philosophy continuity; coordinator play-calling responsibility changes.
OC / play caller	◆ Holmon Wiggins - internal promotion from co-OC/WR; offensive play-caller	● ↔ Internal promotion preserves terminology and QB/skill continuity.
DC / play caller	Lyle Hemphill - internal promotion; defensive play-caller	● ↔ Internal promotion lowers installation risk, but the rebuilt front raises uncertainty.
Co-DC / DL	Elijah Robinson - from Syracuse	● ↔ Adds familiar program context to the defensive-line rebuild.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ WR Isaiah Horton	Alabama	● ↔ Major-role transfer who deepens the WR group after WR KC Concepcion's departure.
◆ OL Tyree Adams / Coen Echols / Trovon Baugh / Wilkin Formby	Transfer group	● ↔ Four transfers compete for four open jobs around C Mark Nabou Jr.; cohesion remains unproven.
◆ TE Richie Anderson III / Houston Thomas	Transfer group	● ↔ Major-rotation candidates who help replace veteran TE losses.

Out	To	Loss
WR KC Concepcion	NFL (Cleveland), Round 1, No. 24	● ↓ First-round WR loss; the returning WR core and WR Isaiah Horton soften but do not erase it.
OL Chase Bisontis / Trey Zuhn III / Dametrious Crownover / Ar'maj Reed-Adams	Bisontis: NFL (Arizona), Round 2, No. 34; Zuhn: NFL (Las Vegas), Round 3, No. 91; Crownover: NFL (New England), Round 6, No. 196; Reed-Adams: NFL (Buffalo), Round 7, No. 241	● ↓ Four drafted linemen force a transfer-heavy rebuild around C Mark Nabou Jr.
RB Le'Veon Moss	Miami Dolphins	● ↔ Veteran back departs, but RB Rueben Owens II and RB Jamarion Morrow return.
TE Nate Boerkircher	NFL (Jacksonville), Round 2, No. 56	● ↔ Another veteran TE loss leaves several replacement candidates but no identical proven role.

Offensive net: ● ↓ **Meaningful continuity risk**, driven by four drafted OL; the returning QB/WR core prevents a full reset.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ DL/Edge Anto Saka / CJ Mims / Angelo McCullom / Brandon Davis-Swain / Ryan Henderson	Transfer group	● ↔ Deep transfer wave rebuilds the front, but equivalence to the departed veterans is unproven.
◆ LB Ray Coney	Tulsa	● ↔ Butkus-recognized addition in an open LB competition; LB Daymion Sanford's availability remains unsettled.
◆ CB Rickey Gibson III	Tennessee	● ↔ Veteran transfer raises the floor of an open outside-CB competition.

Out	To	Loss
DL/Edge Cashius Howell / Tyler Onyedim / Albert Regis	Howell: NFL (Cincinnati), Round 2, No. 41; Onyedim: NFL (Denver), Round 3, No. 66; Regis: NFL (Jacksonville), Round 3, No. 81	● ↓ Three drafted linemen remove major disruption from the front.
DE Dayon Hayes	Eligibility / graduation	● ↓ A 4.5-sack contributor departs; no signed professional destination is established.

Out	To	Loss
LB Scooby Williams / Taurean York	NFL (UDFA signings)	● ↓ Two material LB losses increase reliance on returning and transfer replacements.
CB/DB Will Lee III / Tyreek Chappell	Will Lee III: NFL (Carolina), Round 4, No. 129; Tyreek Chappell: NFL UDFA (Minnesota)	● ↔ Two secondary contributors leave, but veteran S/nickel continuity remains.

Defensive net: ● ↓ **Meaningful regression risk** in the front seven, partly offset by veteran safety continuity.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Multiple-personnel attack built around established QB Marcel Reed and a deep skill group.	QB Reed plus WR Mario Craver, WR Terry Bussey, RB Rueben Owens II and WR Isaiah Horton.	Protection and run continuity while four OL jobs are rebuilt.
Defense	HC Mike Elko/DC Lyle Hemphill structure built on disruption and faster execution.	Elite 2025 success-rate/EPA/havoc profile plus veteran S Marcus Ratcliffe and S Dalton Brooks.	Front-seven turnover and No. 109 explosive-play prevention.
Special teams	Stable punter, new long snapper and open kicker/return roles.	P Tyler White has Ray Guy recognition.	SP+ No. 99 plus unsettled kicker and return roles.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B+	● ↑	High	QB Marcel Reed is the established starter and central continuity point.
RB	● B	● ↓	Medium-high	RB Rueben Owens II leads the returners, but RB Le'Veon Moss is a material NFL loss.
WR	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	WR Mario Craver and WR Terry Bussey return; WR Isaiah Horton helps offset WR KC Concepcion's first-round departure.
TE	● B–	● ↓	Medium	Returning and transfer options remain, but second-round TE Nate Boerkircher is a material loss.
OL	● B–	● ↓	Low	C Mark Nabou Jr. anchors four open jobs filled heavily by transfers; cohesion is unproven.
DL/Edge	● B	● ↓	Medium-low	DT DJ Hicks anchors a deep transfer reload after three drafted linemen and DE Dayon Hayes depart.
LB	● B–	● ↓	Medium-low	LB Daymion Sanford returns, but availability and the new LB order remain unsettled after major losses.
Secondary	● B+	● ↔	Medium	S Marcus Ratcliffe and S Dalton Brooks anchor the back end; outside CB remains open.
Special teams	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	P Tyler White is stable, but SP+ ranks the unit No. 99 and kicker/return roles remain open.
Coaching	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	HC Mike Elko returns while OC Holmon Wiggins and DC Lyle Hemphill assume primary play-calling roles.
Overall	● A–	● ↔	Medium-low	Top-15 contender quality, discounted for unusually high OL/DL/edge uncertainty.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: preseason honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Mario Craver	WR	● National-level conference star	SEC Coaches first team · SEC Media first team · Biletnikoff · Maxwell · Walter Camp POY	Decorated returning lead receiver after WR KC Concepcion's departure.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Marcel Reed	QB	● Established high-upside starter	Maxwell · Walter Camp POY	Confirmed QB1 and the offense's central stability point.
★ Marcus Ratcliffe	S	● Nationally recognized secondary anchor	Walter Camp second team · Nagurski	Decorated veteran anchor for a reworked secondary.
Mark Nabou Jr.	C	● High-end conference OL anchor	SEC Coaches second team · SEC Media second team · Outland · Rimington	The established OL starter stabilizing four open jobs.
DJ Hicks	DT	● High-end conference defensive anchor	SEC Coaches third team · SEC Media third team	Proven interior returner around whom the new front must form.
Terry Bussey	WR	● High-end multi-role playmaker	SEC Coaches third team · SEC Media third team	Major returning receiver with punt-return value.
Dalton Brooks	S	● High-end returning starter	Bednarik	Gives the rebuilt defense valuable veteran safety continuity.
Ray Coney (TR: Tulsa)	LB	● Transfer starter candidate / upside piece	Butkus	Important starter candidate after major LB losses.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Very hard: a manageable first half gives way to a late contender gauntlet.
Difficulty	● 9/10 · Very hard · SP+ SOS No. 14
Hardest stretch	at Alabama → bye → at South Carolina → Tennessee → at Oklahoma → Texas
Swing games	at LSU, at Missouri, at Alabama, at Oklahoma, Texas
Advantage	Three opening home games, The Citadel before Alabama, and a bye before the final four-game SEC close.
Expected	8.5 wins · most likely 9-3
Floor / ceiling	7-5 / 11-1

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	AP, SEC media and SP+ all price A&M as a contender. Trench replacement is the main structural risk, while a secondary ceiling question is whether QB Marcel Reed can sustain longer passing drives when opponents take away the cheap run/explosive answers.
Back them when	The opponent cannot dominate the lines and the price leaves room for early OL/DL transition.
Fade/pass when	Premium pricing assumes 2025 protection/havoc survives automatically against an elite opposing front.
Key monitor	Four OL jobs, front rotation/pass rush, LB Daymion Sanford availability, outside CB/nickel order, kicker/return roles, late injuries
Week 1 baseline	vs. Missouri State: no independent preseason fair line; use the live market as the opening benchmark. Live market: Texas A&M –40.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Texas A&M has top-10 contender quality because QB Marcel Reed, a deep skill group and veteran safeties sit atop an excellent 2025 efficiency baseline. The roster is much less settled in both trenches.

The season turns on whether four new OL jobs and a rebuilt defensive front can stabilize before the schedule hardens. If they do, 9-3 is the likeliest path with a credible SEC and playoff ceiling.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [fall preview](#) · [fall camp](#) · [WR KC Concepcion draft](#) · [NFL draft exits](#) · [portal tracker](#)

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